

NICHE VALIDATION SCORECARD

Niche Validation Scorecard (Founder SOP)

What it is: The same style of checklist Kevis uses before entering a niche — expanded into a scored rubric a busy professional can run alone in 10–15 minutes.

When to use it:

- After Day 4–6 of costuming (homepage goldmine)
- Before you hire an editor or buy a month of tools
- Anytime a “hot niche” video makes you want to switch

What it is not: A guarantee. Passing the scorecard means “worth a controlled test,” not “you will make \$X.”

How to load this (1 page)

Google Sheets

1. Open Google Sheets → File → Import → Upload `02-scorecard-fillable.csv`
2. Duplicate the blank row for each candidate channel
3. Color: Fail cells red, Pass green (optional)

Notion

1. New database → Merge with CSV / Import
2. Properties: Score number, Verdict select (PASS / BORDERLINE / KILL), URL, Notes

Claude

1. New chat or Project with this MD + CSV attached
 2. Paste: Score this channel against the HeadStart scorecard. Channel URL: ... I watched 10 minutes. Notes: ...
 3. Require Claude to fill every criterion or mark UNKNOWN — never invent RPM.
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Philosophy (from teaching — not guru slop)

You don’t need a secret niche. You need a **better way to decide** whether an opportunity is worth entering:

1. **Demographic arbitrage** — older living-room viewers → advertisers pay more (teaching ranges often cited: ~\$8–\$20 RPM on mature topics vs ~\$2 on teen/trend niches).
2. **Low entry barrier** — \$20–\$30 sofa edit, no face, no film crew.
3. **Not AI slop that gets banned** — repeatable documentary / archive / public-footage formats with compliance where needed.
4. **Emergence** — young channels where views beat subs beat “graveyard” 170k-sub / 16k-view corpses.

5. **Winning format evidence** — more than one upload proving the structure, not a 1-upload fluke.

Kevis's self-improvement year: monetized, **~\$2 RPM**, first payday ~\$3, ~\$1,000 over six months while thinking 1,000-view drips meant progress. The scorecard exists so you don't romanticize the wrong niche for a year.

Scoring model

Each criterion: **0 / 1 / 2**

- **0** = Fail / high risk
- **1** = Weak / needs proof
- **2** = Clear pass

Max = 24 (12 criteria × 2)

Total	Verdict	Action
20–24	PASS	Plan first 10 videos. Controlled spend.
15–19	BORDERLINE	Fix the weak criteria or park. Do not scale editors yet.
0–14	KILL	Next candidate. Spend \$0.

Hard gates (automatic KILL even if total is high)

Any of these = **KILL**, ignore the points:

1. Needs a charismatic face / personal brand to work
2. Requires on-location film crew or owned restoration shop
3. Teen / challenge / kids / Roblox-Minecraft-anime primary feed neighbors
4. Clear copyright landmine you cannot license (ripping BBC, full movies, unlicensed music beds as the product)
5. Pure AI-slop pattern YouTube is actively nuking in that vertical (identical voice + identical stock every 3 seconds + no research value) — if you can't articulate the **value add**, kill

The 12 criteria

A. Money & demo (why RPM)

ID	Criterion	0	1	2
A1	Audience age / demo	Teen / Gen-Z challenge energy	Mixed / unclear	Clearly 45–65+ living-room (comments, Suggested neighbors, titles)
A2	Advertiser intent	Entertainment-only / low bid verticals	Mild (general lifestyle)	Money, health, home, retirement, legal, luxury adjacent
A3	RPM evidence	Known low-RPM pattern (teen trends; teaching: ~\$2) or unknown and you refuse to check comps	Teaching-range only; no Studio yet	Similar channels show strong \$ per view in public teaching / your own prior Studio in adjacent niches

Do **not** invent A3 numbers. If unknown → score **1** max and write UNKNOWN.

B. Supply & competition

ID	Criterion	0	1	2
B1	Views vs subs (comp)	Avg views ≤ subs (graveyard)	Mixed library	Views clearly > subs on recent uploads
B2	Channel age / emergence	Ancient + decaying	Mid / unclear	Young or recently re-accelerating; still room
B3	Upload proof (anti-fluke)	1–3 uploads only	4–7	8+ uploads with more than one solid hit

C. Format & ops (owner OS)

ID	Criterion	0	1	2
C1	\$30 edit test	Quotes \$80+ or edit can't be described in one sentence	\$40–60 uncomfortable	Reliable \$20–\$30 sofa documentary edit
C2	No face / no crew	Host-dependent	Occasional face OK but preferred	Fully faceless; stock / archive / public footage
C3	Format repeatability	Every video is a one-off invention	Loose theme	Clear winning format (same psychology, new object each time)
C4	Time-to-first-spin	Weeks of prep before video 1	A few days	Script → \$30 edit → upload inside a week

D. Risk

ID	Criterion	0	1	2
D1	Copyright / footage	Unclear rights; rip culture	Mostly OK with care	Public domain / licensed stock / public bodycam-court with clear sourcing
D2	Compliance / demonetization	Sensational real-crime without care; medical claims as advice	Needs disclaimers	Clear disclaimers / dramatized-fiction firewall / educational framing where needed

Worked examples

Example PASS — “Uncle John–style” retirement finance explainers (pattern from Rick teaching)

- A1=2 older retirees · A2=2 finance/retirement ads · A3=1 (teaching: finance among highest RPMs; no invented channel RPM)
- B1=2 views>>>subs on comps · B2=2 young libraries cited · B3=2 (40+ videos on cited model)
- C1=2 stickman/whiteboard · C2=2 · C3=2 claiming strategies as format · C4=2
- D1=2 public tax code / guidelines · D2=2 educational framing

Total ≈ 21–23 → PASS (still verify your own comps live)

Example KILL — Self-improvement / “lock in” mindset (Kevis origin story)

- A1=1 young/mixed · A2=0 low advertiser bid · A3=0 (~\$2 RPM after monetization on tape)
- B1=1 drip 1k views · B2=1 · B3=1
- C1=1–2 · C2=0–1 often face/personality · C3=1 vague motivation · C4=1
- D1=2 · D2=2

Total low + hard money fail → **KILL / PIVOT** even if “monetized.” Monetization ≠ business.

Example BORDERLINE — Wildlife / backyard birds (NexLev keeper pattern)

- Strong views, faceless, sofa-friendly
- Risk: fluke if only 2 uploads; seasonal; possible low-mid RPM vs finance
- Score often **16–19** → BORDERLINE until 8+ upload proof and you accept RPM profile

Desk card (print)

CHANNEL: _____ URL: _____

WATCHED 10 MIN? [] DATE: _____

A1 Demo ___/2 A2 Advertiser ___/2 A3 RPM evidence ___/2

B1 Views>subs ___/2 B2 Emergence ___/2 B3 Anti-fluke ___/2

C1 \$30 edit ___/2 C2 Faceless ___/2 C3 Repeat format ___/2 C4 Time-to-spin ___/2

D1 Copyright ___/2 D2 Compliance ___/2

TOTAL ___/24 HARD GATE FAIL? [] yes → KILL

VERDICT: PASS / BORDERLINE / KILL

NEXT ACTION: _____

After a PASS

1. Open `05-first-10-videos-planner.md`
2. Extract one winning transcript → pacing clone (see research seeds / Claude pack)
3. Hire with the \$20–\$30 job post pattern (Owner OS)
4. Re-check the pivot tree at video 7 and video 14

If BORDERLINE: fix the weak line or costume deeper — don’t “hope.”

The HeadStart Toolkit · headstartchannels.com/toolkit · CREATIVETUBE LTD. Figures given as teaching ranges are starting hypotheses, not promises. Verify in your own YouTube Studio before you spend money. Nothing here is financial advice.